



# Stems for shape and texture

While bright colors shout “look at me,” contrasting shapes and textures can be used as the *corps de ballet*, supporting and defining a planting design scheme.

Although most stem textures are quite subtle, creating intrigue as you get up close, a few also compete for center stage. The cinnamon-colored peeling trunks of paper-bark maple and shaggy orange and white stems of the river birch are hard to miss and make beautiful focal points. Twisted stems also provide impact, particularly in winter. If you have space, the wiggly stems of the dragon’s-claw willow make a dramatic display. In small gardens, include a Harry Lauder’s walking stick with its mop of curly stems and dangling catkins which appear in spring.



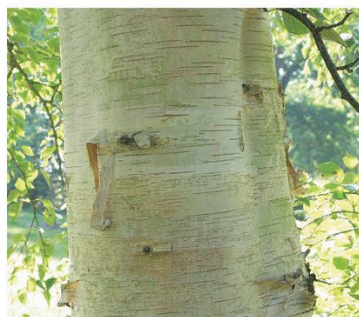
TREE LARGE

## *Betula nigra*

**RIVER BIRCH** The peeling bark of this upright deciduous tree creates eye-catching texture, and looks especially effective when contrasted with the yellow spring catkins. The diamond-shaped green leaves turn yellow in fall.

↑50ft (15m) ↔30ft (10m)

☹ ☀ ☀ Z4–9 (N)



TREE LARGE

## *Betula papyrifera*

**PAPER BIRCH** This tall deciduous birch tree is narrow, and sparsely branched when young, with a smooth white bark that peels in broad scrolling pieces to reveal its pale orange reverse. Perfect as a multistemmed specimen.

↑70ft (20m) ↔30ft (10m)

☹ ☀ ☀ Z2–7 (N)



TREE MEDIUM

## *Acer griseum*

**PAPER-BARK MAPLE** One of the best specimens for textural interest, this spreading deciduous tree has cinnamon flaking bark. Remove lower stems to show off the trunk. It also has lobed leaves that turn bright orange and red in fall.

↑↔30ft (10m)

☹ ☀ ☀ Z4–8



TREE LARGE

## *Cedrus atlantica* Glauca Group

**BLUE ATLAS CEDAR** This evergreen conifer has a spreading tiered crown. The young loosely conical tree has slender dipping branches covered in silvery blue-green needles that create an attractive tracery.

↑130ft (40m) ↔30ft (10m)

☹ ☀ ☀ Z6–9



BAMBOO LARGE

## *Chusquea culeou*

**CHILEAN BAMBOO** A clump-forming bamboo with glossy yellow-green canes that have long, white papery leaf sheaths. The resulting striped effect is a feature. Remove weak canes and the bottom third of side branches to enhance the look.

↑15ft (5m) ↔8ft (2.5m) or more

☹ ☀ ☀ Z8–11



SHRUB LARGE

## *Corylus avellana* 'Contorta'

**HARRY LAUDER'S WALKING STICK** This deciduous shrub has corkscrew stems and broad distorted oval leaves. In winter and early spring, its sculptural branches hang with catkins. Considered invasive in the Northwest and some areas of the Northeast.

↑↔15ft (5m)

☹ ☀ ☀ Z4–8



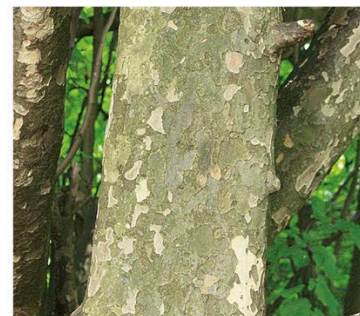
PERENNIAL LARGE

## *Dicksonia antarctica*

**AUSTRALIAN TREE FERN** An evergreen fern for a large pot, this perennial has a fibrous “trunk” made up of old leaf bases, creating a chevron pattern. On top is a “shuttlecock” of much-divided leaves and unfurling fronds. Overwinter indoors.

↑up to 20ft (6m) or more ↔12ft (4m)

☹ ☀ ☀ Z9–11



TREE SMALL

## *Parrotia persica*

**PERSIAN IRONWOOD** In winter, this wide-spreading tree or large shrub, shows a pattern of peeling bark on its multiple stems. Outer brown layers drop, revealing a patchwork of grays, greens, and whites. The fall leaf color is stunning.

↑25ft (8m) ↔30ft (10m)

☹ ☀ ☀ Z4–8